Complex PTSD comes from harm that repeated over time, usually when you were too young or too trapped to leave. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

CPTSD develops after prolonged, repeated trauma rather than a single event. Alongside the usual trauma symptoms it involves difficulties with emotional regulation, a persistently negative self-view, and trouble in relationships. When it happens during childhood it shapes brain development — which is why many people describe it as a form of neurodivergence rather than simply an illness.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Reacting to something small with a force that surprises even you.
- Scanning every room and every face for signs something's about to go wrong.
- Apologising constantly, for existing as much as anything.
- Going numb and distant when things get difficult, without choosing to.
- Struggling to believe good things or kind people will stay.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"That was years ago."	Time doesn't undo how a developing brain adapted to survive.
"It wasn't that bad."	CPTSD comes from repetition and inescapability, not from single dramatic events.
"They're being dramatic."	A nervous system trained for danger reacts as if there's danger. That's not performance.
"They should just move on."	Recovery is real and possible, but it's therapeutic work, not a decision.
"It's the same as PTSD."	It overlaps, but adds lasting effects on self-image, emotions and relationships.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Extraordinary ability to read a room and its moods.

Deep empathy, often for people others overlook.

Practical competence built out of necessity, very young.

Fierce protectiveness of anyone vulnerable.

Real courage — recovery asks a great deal and people do it anyway.

What actually helps

- ☐ Be consistent and predictable
- ☐ Give warning before change
- ☐ Let them leave any situation freely
- ☐ Say what you mean, and mean it
- ☐ Don't push for the story
- ☐ Support trauma-informed therapy

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"That makes sense, given everything."

"You're safe here."

"Take as long as you need."

LESS HELPFUL

"But that was ages ago."

"Other people had it worse."

"Have you tried forgiving them?"

Your nervous system learned to keep you alive. It's allowed to take a while to unlearn it.

If you are struggling right now, you don't have to wait until it gets worse. In the UK you can call Samaritans free on 116 123, any time, or contact your GP. Elsewhere, your local crisis line or doctor is the place to start.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk